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ENGL 1168: Cultural Studies

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Project 5

Disability as an Environment: High-Functioning Autism and the Classroom

High-functioning autism creates a paradox inside modern education. The label "high-functioning" suggests intelligence and independence; "autism" still gets read mostly through disability and social difficulty. How can someone be both highly capable and disabled at once? The mistake is assuming disability lives only inside the individual. My argument is that disability is also something an environment can produce.

This matters especially in schools, because educational spaces are not neutral. Classrooms reward certain ways of thinking, speaking, sitting, paying attention, and proving intelligence. A student who can speak quickly in discussion, work easily in groups, switch tasks on command, tolerate noise, and make eye contact will look more "functional" than one who thinks deeply but communicates differently. For students with high-functioning autism, the issue is usually not a lack of ability—it is that the classroom is built around narrow definitions of ability.

High-functioning autism should be understood as relational: it becomes disabling or empowering depending on the environment surrounding the student. Schools claim to measure intelligence, but they often measure conformity to neurotypical behavior instead. If education rewarded deep focus, pattern recognition, and independent reasoning as much as it rewards speed and social fluency, autistic students would be disabled less by cognition and more by the structure of school. This isn't to romanticize autism or pretend every autistic trait is a hidden strength. Social communication difficulties, sensory overload, executive functioning issues, and anxiety can all be real. The point is that disability gets shaped by the fit between a person and an environment. A staircase disables a wheelchair user more than a ramp does. A loud, constantly shifting classroom disables an autistic student more than a structured, sensory-aware one. The better question is not "How do we fix autistic students?" but "How do educational environments decide which minds count as capable?"

The Old Model vs. the Environmental Model

Old Model of Disability	Environmental Model of Disability
Disability is located inside the student.	Disability emerges between the student and the environment.
The student must adapt to the classroom.	The classroom can also adapt to the student.
Autism is mainly a deficit.	Autism includes challenges and cognitive differences.
Success means acting more neurotypical.	Success means creating conditions where different minds can perform.

The Medical Frame and Its Limits

The dominant way of defining autism comes from clinical systems like the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders. The DSM-5-TR defines autism spectrum disorder mostly through deficits: social communication difficulties, restricted interests, repetitive behavior, and trouble adapting to change. This framework is useful in some ways. It gives doctors, schools, and families a shared language and can make invisible struggles visible enough to qualify a student for support.

The clinical frame has a real limitation, though, in that it tends to describe autistic people through what they lack. In my Project 3, I argued that psychological frameworks define autism primarily as impairment—something to be treated or managed. That problem gets sharper in education, because schools take diagnostic language and translate it into assumptions about classroom performance. If autism is defined mainly through difficulty with social interaction, then a student who avoids eye contact, dislikes group work, or speaks in a monotone gets read as less engaged or less mature, even when their intellectual work is strong.

The phrase “high-functioning” adds another layer of trouble. It sounds positive, but it can hide difficulty. A student labeled high-functioning is often expected to manage without support because they get good grades or speak well in certain contexts. At the same time, the label becomes a measure of worth: the autistic student is accepted as long as they appear productive,

gifted, or useful. “High-functioning” ends up describing less about the student and more about how well the student can pass inside a neurotypical environment.

Ian Hacking’s work on diagnostic categories is useful here, because he argues labels do not just describe people—they shape how people understand themselves. A label like high-functioning autism influences how teachers interpret behavior, how classmates interpret social difference, and how autistic students interpret their own value. If a student repeatedly learns their intelligence is impressive but their social behavior is a problem, they may begin to see their own mind as split between gift and defect. Schools praise autistic strengths in theory while punishing autistic behavior in practice.

Neurodiversity and the Question of Difference

The neurodiversity movement challenges the idea that neurological differences should automatically be treated as disorders. Judy Singer’s concept of neurodiversity frames autism as a natural variation in human minds rather than a failure of normal development. This does not erase disability, but it changes the starting point. Instead of asking why autistic students are broken, neurodiversity asks why only certain kinds of minds are treated as normal in the first place.

Thomas Armstrong’s work on neurodiversity in education matters here because he argues that schools often create disability through narrow definitions of intelligence. In Project 3, I used Armstrong to ask whether high-functioning autism would still seem as disabling if schools valued deep focus and independent reasoning as much as social fluency. Project 5 pushes that question further: autism becomes disabling in school when educational systems confuse one style of learning with learning itself.

A student who processes information slowly may not be less intelligent—they may just need more time to organize their thoughts. A student who dislikes group work may not be antisocial; they may work better through independent concentration. A student who does not make eye contact may still be listening carefully. A student who asks detailed questions may not be challenging authority; they may be trying to understand the system fully before acting on it. Many traits that schools read as problems are actually mismatches between autistic cognition and

neurotypical classroom expectations. The issue is not just what autistic students can or cannot do. It is how schools define proof of engagement, intelligence, and respect.

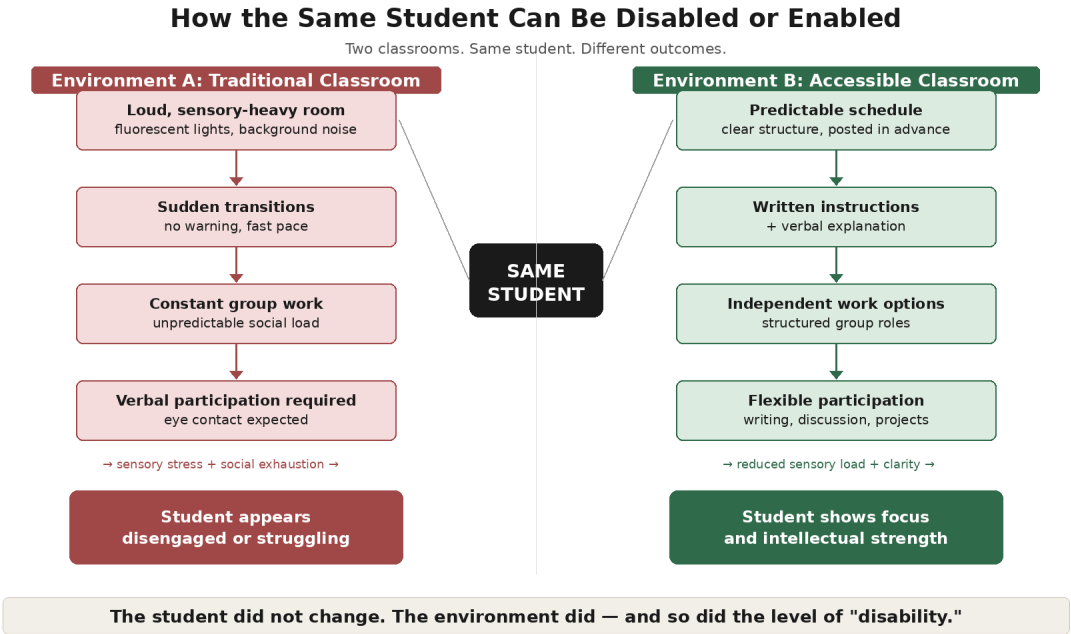
Simon Baron-Cohen's research on systemizing and pattern-seeking complicates the deficit model further. He argues many autistic individuals show strong abilities in systems, patterns, and rule-based thinking—traits valuable in fields like engineering, math, computer science, and data analysis. I have seen this directly: a younger autistic family member of mine, still in high school, has walked me through college-level engineering math I could not work through on my own. In many classrooms, though, those strengths get overshadowed by social expectations. A student can be excellent at identifying patterns in a physics problem and still struggle in a noisy group lab, and the school often treats the social struggle as more important than the analytical strength.

Disability as a Relationship, Not a Fixed Trait

Disability studies gives this argument a deeper foundation. Lennard Davis argues the idea of "normal" is not natural or timeless—it is historically constructed. Once a society invents a standard of normal behavior, bodies and minds that fall outside it get marked as abnormal. High-functioning autism is judged against unstated norms: make eye contact, respond quickly, read tone, sit still, participate verbally, handle transitions, work in groups, appear socially comfortable. Those norms are not neutral. They assume good students are socially smooth, verbally quick, and emotionally regulated in public. When autistic students struggle with those expectations, schools define the struggle as evidence of individual deficit rather than evidence the environment is too narrow.

This is why disability should be understood relationally. A student with high-functioning autism might struggle in a fluorescent, noisy classroom with unpredictable transitions and constant group work. That same student might thrive in a quiet room with written instructions, predictable routines, independent work time, and a teacher who allows alternative forms of participation. The student did not become more or less autistic between those two rooms. The environment changed, and the level of disability changed with it. Disability is not only a condition; it is also a design outcome.

How the Same Student Can Be Disabled or Enabled



The Classroom as a Cultural Machine

A classroom is more than a physical room. It is a cultural machine that produces definitions of success. Desks, schedules, participation grades, group projects, timed tests, and behavioral expectations all communicate what kind of student the institution wants. For autistic students labeled high-functioning, this gets confusing because their strengths often do not match the school's preferred performance style. A student may have strong memory, deep interest, visual thinking, or systems-based reasoning, but if the class values quick verbal response over depth, that student looks weaker than they are. Temple Grandin's Thinking in Pictures describes visual thinking as another mode of processing the world—cognition that is different rather than inferior.

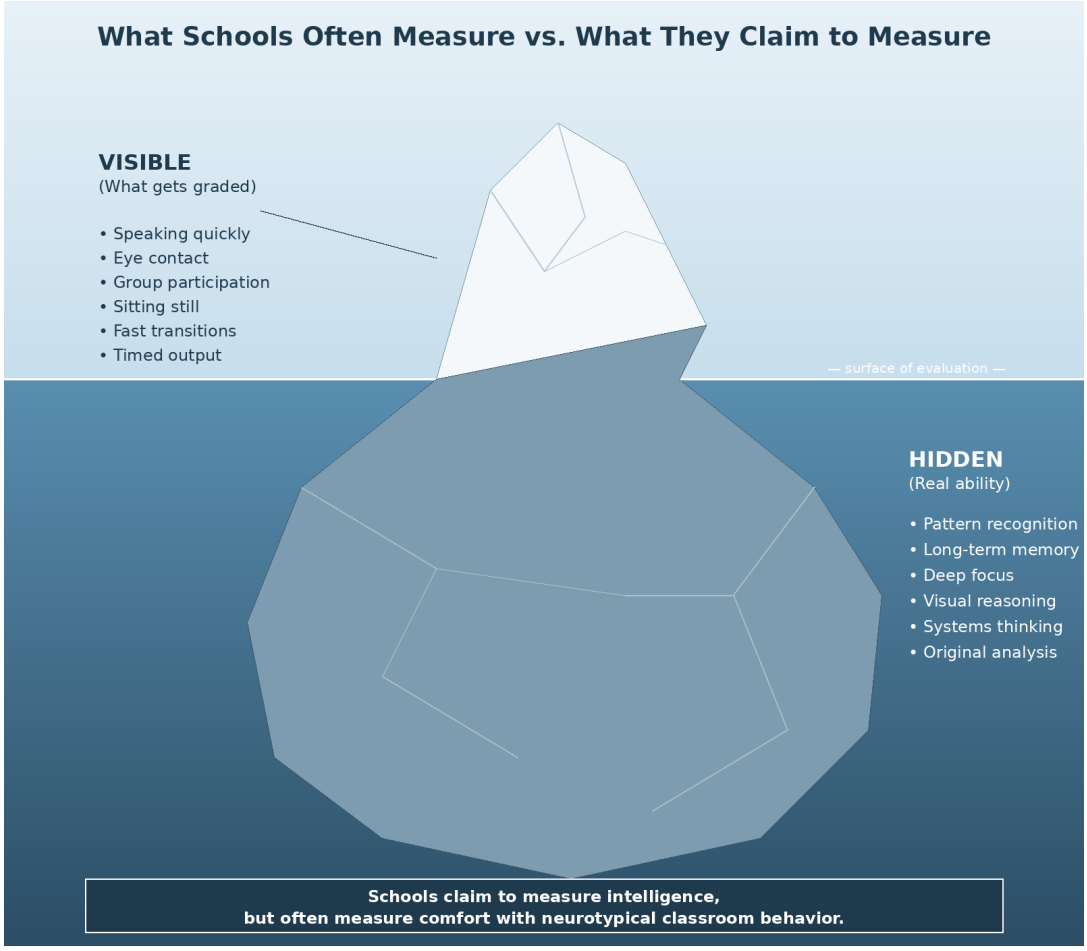
Schools often mistake presentation for ability. A student who speaks confidently is assumed to understand deeply; a student who is quiet or awkward is assumed not to. These assumptions measure performance under social pressure, not knowledge. Participation grades are one example: in many classes, "participation" means speaking out loud in front of others, which

privileges extroverted communication. A student who writes thoughtful responses, contributes in online discussion, asks questions after class, or shows understanding through projects is participating intellectually, just not in the expected form. If the class only recognizes one version, it disables students whose communication doesn't fit. Group work creates a similar problem—constant collaboration requires reading tone, managing unpredictable dynamics, shifting roles, and filtering sensory input. A school might read discomfort with group work as a lack of teamwork, when the real issue is that the assignment has no structure. Timed testing measures knowledge, but also processing speed, stress tolerance, and executive functioning. Extra time isn't an unfair advantage; it is a correction for an environment that otherwise measures the wrong thing.

"High-Functioning" and the Cost of Passing

The phrase "high-functioning" hides how much work it takes to look functional. Many autistic students learn to mask—they consciously imitate neurotypical behavior to avoid judgment. They force eye contact, suppress stimming, rehearse conversations, copy classmates' social behavior, and hide sensory distress. From the outside, masking can make a student look successful; internally, it is exhausting. The label measures how well a student performs normalcy, not how much support they actually need. A student who earns good grades may still be overwhelmed by social demands. A student who appears calm may be burning enormous energy to hide distress. Steven Kapp's work on the neurodiversity movement matters here because it centers autistic voices instead of only outside observation. If autistic students say an environment is overwhelming, that should count as knowledge. Schools too often treat professional expertise as objective and autistic experience as subjective, but lived experience is also evidence. Teachers should not only ask, "Is this student meeting the standard?" but "What standard am I asking them to meet, and does it measure learning or just conformity?"

What Schools Often Measure vs. What They Claim to Measure



Reframing Accommodation

If disability is environmental, then accommodation is not about lowering the standard. It is about redesigning the path to the standard. A lower standard says, “This student cannot do the real work.” An accessible environment says, “This student can do the work if the conditions allow their ability to show.” For high-functioning autistic students, helpful accommodations include written instructions, predictable schedules, reduced sensory distractions, flexible participation, independent work options, clear rubrics, structured group roles, quiet spaces, and flexible testing. None of this removes academic rigor. It often makes assessment more accurate, because it separates knowledge from unnecessary environmental barriers.

The goal is not to make autistic students less autistic. It is to make educational spaces less dependent on one narrow model of normal behavior. Many autistic students thrive when information is organized visually, spatially, and predictably. A classroom that uses diagrams, schedules, concept maps, and rubrics is not just "easier"—it is more intellectually accessible. Order can be a form of care. At the same time, order cannot mean rigidity. An accessible classroom needs both structure and flexibility: structure reduces uncertainty, and flexibility lets students show knowledge in different ways.

Why This Matters Beyond One Diagnosis

If specialists keep defining autism mainly through deficit, schools will keep treating autistic students as problems to manage. If autism is instead understood as a relationship between cognition and environment, schools become responsible for changing too. This doesn't mean every classroom can be perfectly redesigned for every student. It does mean institutions should stop pretending current norms are neutral. The standard classroom already accommodates some students: the ones who can sit still, process speech quickly, handle noise, and switch tasks easily. Those students are not succeeding in a neutral system. They are succeeding in a system built around them.

For high-functioning autistic students, the stakes are especially high because their needs are often invisible. Students with more obvious support needs may get accommodations more quickly, while students who seem intelligent are expected to "figure it out." But intelligence does not cancel disability. The high-functioning label can actually make disability harder to see, because teachers assume that academic strength means the student should not need help. That assumption causes real damage: burnout, anxiety, isolation, and self-blame. The student concludes that if they are smart but still struggling, something must be personally wrong with them. An environmental model changes that story—the problem may not be your mind. The problem may be the fit between your mind and the system.

Conclusion

High-functioning autism reveals a larger truth about education: schools do not simply discover ability—they produce the conditions under which ability becomes visible. When schools reward only neurotypical communication, social fluency, and quick verbal response, they

make some students appear more capable than others. But those measures do not define intelligence. They define comfort inside a specific environment.

"Disability as an environment" means schools have more responsibility than they often admit. If classrooms can be disabling, classrooms can also be enabling. If educational systems can make autistic students seem less capable, then better-designed systems can reveal abilities that were already there. High-functioning autism is not just a contradiction between giftedness and impairment. It is a mirror held up to education itself. It shows that what we call "functioning" usually means functioning under conditions built for someone else. A better school system would not ask autistic students to become normal before recognizing their intelligence. It would ask how "normal" was designed in the first place, who benefits from that design, and what kinds of minds have been left outside the room.